



## FORCING AND BLANCHING

Forcing Witloof chicory will produce a crop of blanched leaf shoots that are less bitter in taste than the green leaves. Dig up mature plants in late fall to early winter. Cut the leaves off the plant to within 1 in (2.5 cm) above the root collar, and trim the bottom of the root so that it measures 8 in (20 cm) in length. Plant these trimmed roots in boxes of moist potting compost, so that their tops are just showing above the soil surface. Then cover with 9 in (23 cm) of compost. Move the box to a warm dark place for three to four weeks.

## PESTS AND DISEASES

Chicory may be at risk from slugs and snails, which will happily munch their way through leaves. To deter them, create a protective barrier using a cloche or cold frame; set up beer traps to draw them away from crops; and lay a ring of coarse material such as sand or diatomaceous earth (DE) around the planting area. Alternatively, use slug pellets, as these are the most effective control. Keep a close eye out for aphids, too. If infestations are severe, spray with insecticide.